IT is an old story, with a fresh chapter being written into it every so often. This May, it was a German charter flight of 253 Indians that was sent back from Jamaican capital Kingston to Dubai on suspicion of human trafficking. A few of the passengers were scheduled to travel to Nicaragua and others to Canada after a supposed week-long stay in Jamaica, although only one day was accounted for. Officers of the Criminal Investigation Department (Crime) of Gujarat suspect that around 75 passengers from the state and a few from Punjab were attempting to migrate to the US illegally.

How does it feel to be sent back? It has been over seven months since Raman Thakor, 32, was deported from Vatry in France last year. Back now in Mehsana, a city in agrarian north Gujarat, there is not a single day when he does not think of going back. "This was his third failed attempt [at illegal immigration]," his wife Alpita, 30, tells us between sobs, even as her three-year-old daughter tries to wipe her tears while playing with a balloon. "Earlier, he had to return from Vietnam and Indonesia after agents duped him." He is raring to go again, a thought that distresses Alpita no end, although Thakor's parents are unperturbed. "They are confident that he will reach the US somehow and, once there, all our financial troubles will be over," says Alpita. "But what about me and our children?"

Thakor was one of the 303 Indian passengers aboard a Nicaragua-bound Romanian charter plane that was grounded for four days at Vatry on suspicion of human trafficking. Although all passengers possessed valid travel documents, some of them confessed to wanting to unlawfully cross into the US via Mexico. Twenty-seven applied for asylum in France, while the remaining 276, including 96 from Gujarat and others from Punjab and Haryana, were repatriated. Later, upon their return to their native places in Mehsana, Gandhinagar and Patan in the north and Anand in central Gujarat, the CID (Crime) arrested 15 agents.

With incidents like these getting reported frequently statewide, investigators have been chasing visa agents, middlemen and facilitators ('donkers' in human trafficking circles) who operate within sophisticated cartels across multiple nations. Data from the United States Customs and Border Protection (USCBP) for September 2023 shows a fivefold surge in Indian illegal immigrants since 2019-20—96,917 people were apprehended between October 2022 and September 2023, compared to 19,883 in 2019-20.

But hard statistics cannot reflect the actual hardships these desperate men and women endure. Cinema, like the Shah Rukh Khan-starrer *Dunki* (the Punjabi word for the act of moving from one location to another), a tale of friends from a Punjab village aiming to reach England released last November, offers only a slice of life. But it takes a tragedy like the one that befell Praveen Chaudhary and his family of four in March 2023 to stir humanity's collective soul. The boat that the Chaudharys were in capsized on the St Lawrence River during their illegal attempt to enter the US from the Quebec-New York border in Canada. In January 2022, another family of four—including Jagdish Patel's three-year-old child—from Dingucha village in Mehsana died in a blizzard while trying to cross into the US from Canada. Two persons, including Gujarati-origin Harshkumar Patel a.k.a. 'Dirty Harry', were indicted for their deaths by a

*Names of immigrants and their family members have been changed



FATAL ATTRACTION

INDIANS DETAINED FOR ILLEGAL BORDER CROSSING IN THE US

19,883 (2019-20)

96,917* (Oct.'22-Sept.'23)

Caught on the Canada border	*30,010
on Mexico border	*41,770

Source: US Customs and Border Protection, Sept. 2023

725,000
Illegal Indian immigrants in the US, third largest after Mexico and El Salvador

4.4-5.4%
of all US workers are unauthorised immigrants since 2003

Source: Pew Research Center report, Nov. 2023

"EARLIER, WE FLEW DIRECTLY TO MEXICO, BUT THE OFFICIALS THERE HAVE BECOME GREEDY... NOW, WE FLY INTO MEXICO FROM DIFFERENT COUNTRIES TO AVOID THEIR ATTENTION. WE KNOW IT IS A MATTER OF TIME BEFORE THIS GETS BUSTED. WE WILL CROSS THAT BRIDGE SOON"

–AN AGENT, *35, Mehsana*